Keynote Speaker

Katharine Neil
Game sound designer/programmer
Atari Melbourne House

Adaptive audio in games

Abstract

There is nothing in the least highbrow or esoteric about interactive computer music. In fact, it is more commonplace to interact with adaptive, algorithmically generated music and audio than it is to listen to Britney Spears. That is, assuming there are less Britney Spears fans in the world today than there are gamers.

Nor is there anything particularly surprising about the ubiquity of interactive music. Gamers demand it. Thousands of sound designers and composers have spent years agonising over their seemingly impossible brief: to turn minutes worth of sound effects and music into a "movie quality" game soundtrack of forty hours or more.

This talk will give an overview of the history of adaptive game audio, its role in the context of gameplay, and the technologies and techniques of game audio as they relate to sound art: including game as performance interface, coopting console audio hardware, and non-linear music authoring systems.

Biography

Katharine Neil has been game sound designer and programmer at Atari Melbourne House since 1998. While young in relative terms, she started studying computer music (at the University of Auckland then at La Trobe University, Melbourne) when people actually went around saying that "electronic music will never catch on". She has created the sound for seven published game titles on various platforms while creating audio-based "demos" for game console hardware in her spare time.